

ABID BHAT

THE NEW BLIGHT
Gulzar Ahmad Bhat at his apple orchard in Chandgam, Pulwama. A single pesticide spray damaged his crop in July 2024

KASHMIR

A BITTER HARVEST

Kashmir horticulture department, in consultation with the Sher-e-Kashmir University of Agricultural Sciences and Technology, prescribes recommended agrochemicals each season. In Bhat's case, the department later confirmed that a non-recommended chemical had caused the devastation.

Bhat isn't alone. Kashmir's apple industry—supporting 3.5 million people and contributing over 75 per cent of India's apple production—is battling an unchecked influx of toxic, substandard and counterfeit agrochemicals. Growers are increasingly alarmed as unregulated products wreak havoc on orchards and livelihoods. The issue was even raised in the J&K assembly recently by Hilal Akbar Lone and Bashir Ahmad Veeri of the ruling National Conference. Responding to them on March 19, agriculture minister Javid Ahmad Dar denied malpractice while maintaining that adequate testing protocols are in place. Paradoxically, demand for agrochemicals has surged due to rising orchard diseases—linked to climate change and imported foreign varieties introduced in high-density plantations.

Kashmir's horticulture sector contributes nearly 7 per cent to J&K's Gross State Domestic Product. Driven by government subsidies since being introduced in 2016, high-density plantations now cover 3,000 hectares, though traditional orchards still span 170,000 hectares. Together, they produce over two million tonnes (MT) of apples annually, with high-density orchards accounting for a tenth of the crop. Regulations around foreign varieties have also loosened. Earlier, imported saplings had to be planted immediately post-quarantine. Now, they can be stored in cold facilities, which farmers say has opened the door to more diseases and therefore heightened chemical dependence. Pests like leaf miner have proliferated, giving sleepless nights to farmers and opening lucrative markets for chemical manufacturers and unscrupulous traders.

The law enforcement directorate, which operates as a wing of the agriculture department, oversees the supply and sale of agrochemicals. Between 2024 and 2025, of the 2,564 pesticide samples tested in J&K, 910 failed quality checks. Similarly, 138 of 1,037 fertiliser samples were found substandard. In Kashmir alone, where the horticulture industry thrives, 2,543 cases of related malpractices have been reported since 2022, but only 235 resulted in FIRs.

Big brands like FIL, BASF, IndoFil and Bayer still dominate the shelves, but even they haven't escaped scrutiny. In 2024, two specific products from FIL and IndoFil were de-

CHEMICAL CRISIS

- **Surge in counterfeit and misbranded agrochemicals is devastating apple orchards in Kashmir, putting 3.5 million livelihoods in jeopardy**
- **Rising pest attacks, exacerbated by climate change and imported plant varieties, has fuelled chemical dependence**
- **Delays in testing fertiliser and pesticide samples along with poor enforcement on the ground has compounded the challenge**